heavily in developing state-of-the-art physical infrastructure across the country. It has greatly improved its Human Development Index over the years. These are not beyond the capacity of a democracy. Authoritarianism does not deliver good governance, as one has seen in a large number of similar states. One should not draw the wrong conclusions from the Chinese experience.

I believe that India has a better chance of meeting the China challenge by remaining committed to the values enshrined in its Constitution, upholding democratic institutions, investing in its people and celebrating its diversity and its vibrant plural culture. It has the opportunity to pioneer a different strategy of growth, which is ecologically more sustainable and may offer a more attractive model to emulate than China. The race is not over yet.

Halford Mackinder (1861–1947), British geographer, author of The Geopolitical Pivot of History.

Alfred Thayer Mahan (1840–1914), American naval officer and strategist, author of The Influence of Sea Power Upon History.

William H. McNeill, The Rise of the West: A History of the Human Community, University of Chicago Press, 1963.